

A Coloured World: Inkjet and Laser Printers

Inkjet printers have become popular due to the fact that they provide users with the ability to print in colour at a fraction of the cost of basic monochrome laser printers. The prices for inkjet printers begin from about Rs 5,000 and go up to Rs 50,000.

Laser printers are used in office environments, where fast, high-quality, economical and hassle-free printing is needed. Prices of laser printers begin from about Rs 17,000 for a basic laser printer and go up to over Rs 1,00,000 for a full-blown network printer.

Technology Insight

Inkjets work by placing

charged ink particles onto paper by using magnetised plates to direct the ink into the required patterns.

A laser printer uses a laser beam to draw the document on a selenium-coated drum using electrical charges. The drum is then rolled in toner—a dry powder-like ink. The toner adheres to the charged image on the drum, and is transferred and fused onto a paper with heat and pressure.

Smart tips

Resolution: This is measured in dots per inch (dpi), and is a rough measure of the image quality output.

Laser printers can better an Inkjet printer's output at similar resolutions in terms of quality and sharpness, as there isn't any smudging or spreading of ink.

Speed: Print speeds are usually inversely proportional to print quality.

Laser printers offer much higher speeds than Inkjets counterparts. Beginning at about 6 ppm, the speed can go as high as 45 ppm or more.

Colour: Although low-end inkjets don't offer great quality, the high-end ones offer photo quality output when printed at high resolution on glossy paper. Although the cost of printing each colour page is higher than comparable colour laser printers, the price of the printer itself is much lower.

Connections: Check that your computer has the right kind of port for the printer you have selected. While newer models have USB ports, parallel port models are also quite common. For networks, a printer should be able to

connect directly to the network and support the kind of protocols you use.

Paper: Check that the printer accommodates the paper sizes and volumes you plan to use.

Memory: Printers come with a buffer (RAM). A larger buffer allows storage of high-resolution documents or a larger number of regular documents.

Postscript for laser printers: It is important for laser printers to have postscript support. This decreases the time taken to print vector graphics—an advantage in pre-press set-ups and other such graphics-intensive print processes to create colour separation prints etc.

	Medium volume printing	Heavy-duty printing
You need	Cheap, average quality, and decent speed printing	Money no bar, fast and quality printing
Look for	An A4 printer with a resolution of 600 x 1,200 dpi	Resolution of 1,200 x 1,200 dpi, and the ability to handle larger print loads
Our pick	Minolta QMS PagePro 1100	Lexmark Optra M412, HP LaserJet 1220se
Price range	Up to Rs 20,000	Up to Rs 50,000

	Home use	Intermediate	Professional
You need	Cheap, average quality and acceptable speeds.	Fast, better quality, larger paper size support	Photorealistic printouts, quality all important
Look for	An A4 printer with the ability to print colour. Resolution of 1440 x 720 dpi	Faster print speeds, photo cartridges or larger paper sizes up to A3	Resolution of 2,400 x 1,200 or 2,880 x 1,440 dpi. Six colour printing
Our pick	Canon BJC 3000, Epson Stylus Color 880	Lexmark Z52	HP DeskJet 990Cxi
Price Range	Up to Rs 8,000	Up to Rs 15,000	Up to Rs 30,000

Also Remember...

■ The cartridge life is a number that manufacturers arrive at considering that each printout will print ink on only 5 per cent of each page. In reality, the life of a cartridge will vary according to the type of printing you do.

■ Duplexing is the ability to print on both sides of a page. It is a useful paper saving feature but usually costs slightly more.

■ To judge print quality, take a look at a few sample printouts on plain paper before making a decision.

■ Dpi ratings tend to be misleading.



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